



Spirit of sport: The Meghalaya State Government, under Conrad K. Sangma (in pic), is promoting sports and building infrastructure in the state. **Left:** Ri-Bhoi U18 girls' football team won gold after defeating East Khasi Hills in the final.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



MEGHALAYA

The opening and closing ceremonies and the football matches were held at the P.A. Sangma Sports Complex, which is the pride of Tura.

The state-of-the-art sports complex is being built at a cost of ₹127.7 crore and it will have an indoor stadium, a gymnasium, a swimming pool and facilities for conducting table tennis, squash and badminton events. The complex is still under construction and will be ready when Meghalaya hosts the 40th National Games.

The need to have more stadiums was answered to some extent with Tura getting the State's second

synthetic track. The new athletics stadium, named after Garo freedom fighter Po Togan Nengminja Sangma, was inaugurated for the Games by the Chief Minister, who reiterated his government's commitment to developing sports and said that the state would have new facilities soon.

"The new and refurbished infrastructure is part of a larger sports development plan, including Indoor Hall Hawakhana, Don Bosco College Basketball Court, and Rongkhon Swimming Pool. The Government is committed to investing in sports, with a focus on

better infrastructure, athletes' training, and empowerment of all stakeholders," he said.

President Draupadi Mumru inaugurated the Games in an impressive opening ceremony that showcased the cultural ethos of the State.

On the competition front, the seven-day event drew participants from all districts who took part in 20 disciplines besides three demonstration sports — Mawpin (a Khasi traditional game), Rah Mukrah (a Jaintia traditional game) and Wa' pong Sika (a Garo traditional game).

East Khasi Hills ended up as champion with a haul of 132 gold, 105 silver and 122 bronze medals while Ri-Bhoi came second with a total of 27 gold, 22 silver and 30 bronze medals. West Jaintia Hills was third with 68 medals including 25 gold, 18 silver and 25 bronze. Pdiangsuklang Syngwan of East Khasi Hills was the most bemedalled athlete of the Games with eight in total, including six gold, in the swimming events.

« We have used the Meghalaya Games to test our capability and to improve infrastructure in the Tura district, which will also host a big number of events in the National Games. The Government has agreed to most of our proposals and has raised the cash incentives for sportspersons, winning medals in national and international events — John F. Kharshiing, working president, Meghalaya State Olympic Association (MSOA) »